

Absolutely. Before looking at papers or questionnaires, let's understand your topic from **first principles**. This will help you decide what the variables should be instead of adding variables randomly.

1. Start with the atomic concepts

Your topic is:

Hybrid Learning and Training Effectiveness: Making Digital and In-Person Learning Work Together

Break it into five basic concepts:

Learning → Hybrid Learning → Training → Training Effectiveness → Workplace Performance

2. What is “learning”?

At the most basic level:

Learning = a relatively lasting change in what a person knows, can do, or is able to apply, as a result of experience or instruction.

Think of an employee before and after training.

Before training:

Employee doesn't know a new banking procedure.

↓ Training

After training:

Employee understands the procedure.

But that's not enough.

If the employee forgets it after two weeks, did the training really work?

This gives us the first important distinction:

Learning ≠ temporary exposure to information.

Good learning should produce some degree of **retention and ability to use the knowledge**.

3. What is “training”?

Training is learning that is deliberately organized to improve someone's **knowledge, skills, abilities, or work behaviour** for a particular purpose.

For your study:

Employee training = an organizational intervention intended to improve employees' knowledge, skills and/or job performance.

For example, a bank might train employees on:

- Digital banking
- Cybersecurity
- Customer service
- Compliance
- New banking software
- KYC procedures
- Financial products
- Risk management

The organization doesn't train employees simply so they can complete a course.

The ultimate objective is:

Training → better employee capability → better work performance

4. What is digital learning?

Digital learning means learning delivered or supported through digital technologies.

Examples:

- Online courses
- LMS modules
- Recorded videos
- Webinars
- Mobile learning
- Online quizzes
- Virtual classrooms

- E-learning modules

Its major advantages are:

Flexibility + accessibility + self-paced learning + scalability

But it can have weaknesses:

Lower face-to-face interaction + distractions + technology problems + reduced personal interaction

5. What is in-person learning?

This is traditional face-to-face learning where the trainer and learners interact physically.

Examples:

- Classroom lectures
- Demonstrations
- Role plays
- Group discussions
- Simulations
- Practical exercises
- Question-and-answer sessions

Its major strengths are:

Interaction + immediate feedback + social learning + practical activities

But it can have limitations:

Fixed schedule + location dependence + higher delivery cost + less flexibility

6. Now we reach “hybrid learning”

This is the **core concept of your dissertation**.

Hybrid/blended learning essentially means combining technology-mediated learning with face-to-face learning.

But there is an important principle:

Hybrid learning is NOT simply “online + classroom.”

The important word is **integration**.

Imagine this:

Poor hybrid model

Employee watches three hours of videos online.

Then attends a classroom session where the trainer repeats exactly the same information.

That's technically a combination, but the two modes aren't really working together.

Better hybrid model

Before classroom

Employee completes online modules.

↓

Classroom

Trainer discusses difficult concepts, demonstrates procedures and conducts role plays.

↓

After classroom

Employee completes digital quizzes/revision.

↓

Workplace

Employee applies the learning.

↓

Follow-up

Digital assessment/reinforcement checks retention.

That's a genuinely integrated hybrid model.

This distinction is going to be **very important in your literature review**.

7. What is training effectiveness?

Now ask the fundamental question:

How do we know whether training worked?

That's what **training effectiveness** is about.

At a basic level:

Training effectiveness = the extent to which training achieves its intended learning and work-related outcomes.

It can include several levels:

Level 1 – Reaction

Did employees like the training?

“I found the training useful.”

Level 2 – Learning

Did they actually learn?

“I understand the new banking procedure.”

Level 3 – Retention

Did they remember it later?

“I can still recall the procedure after several weeks.”

Level 4 – Behaviour/application

Can they use it at work?

“I apply what I learned during my daily work.”

Level 5 – Performance

Did their work improve?

Fewer errors, better customer service, faster processing, improved productivity, etc.

This gives you an important chain:

8. Now your dissertation becomes much clearer

Your basic question is not simply:

“Is hybrid learning good?”

Instead, it is:

Does integrating digital and face-to-face learning improve the effectiveness of employee training?

And then:

What explains that relationship?

This second question is exactly what your madam was talking about.

9. Where do the additional variables come in?

Suppose we establish:

Hybrid Learning → Training Effectiveness

We then ask:

Why might hybrid learning be effective?

Perhaps because it increases:

Learner Engagement

Employee participates more actively.

↓

Knowledge Retention

Employee remembers what was taught.

↓

Workplace Application

Employee uses the knowledge.

↓

Training Effectiveness

Work performance improves.

So these aren't random additional variables.

They potentially explain **the mechanism** through which hybrid learning produces an outcome.

10. Think of the variables as a machine

Imagine hybrid learning is an input into a machine.

INPUT

Hybrid learning

↓

MECHANISM

Engagement Motivation Interaction Knowledge retention Satisfaction

↓

OUTPUT

Training effectiveness

↓

FINAL WORKPLACE OUTCOME

Employee performance

This is the kind of thinking your guide is asking you to develop.

11. But every suggested variable doesn't have to be included

Your madam listed:

- Learner engagement
- Knowledge retention
- Learning motivation
- Learner satisfaction
- Digital literacy / technology readiness
- Trainer competence
- Organizational support

Don't immediately make all seven variables part of your model.

Instead ask for each one:

Question 1

Is there a strong theoretical reason this variable matters?

Question 2

Have previous researchers studied it?

Question 3

Does it explain the relationship between hybrid learning and training outcomes?

Question 4

Can it be reliably measured using an established questionnaire?

Question 5

Does it make sense in the **Union Bank employee context**?

That is why your madam wants you to **review the literature first**.

12. A very important distinction: mediator vs moderator

This will become important later.

Mediator

A mediator explains **how/why** X affects Y.

For example:

Hybrid Learning → Learner Engagement → Training Effectiveness

The question is:

Does hybrid learning improve engagement, which then improves training effectiveness?

That's mediation.

Moderator

A moderator explains **when/for whom** X has a stronger or weaker effect.

For example:

Hybrid Learning → Training Effectiveness

but the relationship may be stronger for employees with high:

Digital Literacy

So:

Does digital literacy change the strength of the relationship between hybrid learning and training effectiveness?

That's moderation.

You don't need to decide which variables are mediators/moderators yet. **The literature should guide that decision.**

13. Your topic's first-principles model

At the most fundamental level, we can reduce your dissertation to:

How training works

Exposure → Learning → Retention → Application → Performance

Then introduce the delivery mechanism:

Digital + Face-to-face → Learning process → Training outcomes

And then investigate the mechanisms:

Hybrid Learning → Engagement/Motivation/etc. → Retention/Application → Training Effectiveness

That is the intellectual foundation of your dissertation.

14. What I recommend we do next

Now that the concepts are clear, **don't start collecting questionnaires yet.**

The next step should be a proper literature investigation.

For each candidate variable, we need to find:

Definition → theoretical basis → previous studies → relationship with hybrid learning → relationship with training effectiveness → measurement scale → questionnaire items → reliability (Cronbach's α) → factor analysis → research gap

Then we can make a decision such as:

IV: Hybrid Learning **Mediator:** Knowledge Retention **Mediator/Moderator:** Learner Engagement **DV:** Training Effectiveness / Workplace Performance **Controls:** demographic and job characteristics, if required

—but **only after the literature supports it.**

That approach follows your madam's advice much more closely than simply adding variables to the model.